became known as Israel's national poet. "'Vengeance for the blood of a small child, Satan has not yet created.' Neither has vengeance for the blood of three pure youths who were on their way home to their parents who will not see them anymore. Hamas is responsible and Hamas will pay. May the memories of the three boys be blessed," he wrote.

Netanyahu's supporters argued that his words were misinterpreted, and they have a point. The Bialik quote (the first sentence quoted above) comes from the final stanza of "On the Slaughter", a lamentation the poet wrote shortly after dozens of Jews were killed in a 1903 pogrom in Kishinev. The poem is about Bialik's own crisis of faith—his anger that divine justice did not "show itself immediately". Netanyahu had omitted the first three words, *v'arur haomer "nkom"*, "cursed be he who says, 'avenge!'"

But it is worth considering the larger body of Bialik's work, which is familiar to many Israeli schoolchildren. He wrote a much longer poem in 1904, after interviewing survivors of the massacre, called "In the City of Slaughter". Here he laments not just the inaction of heaven, but also of men, "Crushed in their shame, they saw it all/they did not stir or move/they did not pluck their eyes out/they beat not their brains against the wall"; "they crawled forth from their holes/they fled to the house of the Lord/they offered thanks to Him/the sweet benedictory word."

A century separates the massacre in Kishinev from the murders in Kfar Etzion. The Jews who once "cowered… in their holes" now have a modern state, an army, a legal system. Bialik's words conjure a feeling of Jewish powerlessness and victimhood, from an era when justice was the subject of desperate prayers to an indifferent God. They have little relevance in modern-day Israel. Yet Netanyahu still chose to invoke them.

It was Yossi Melman, a veteran journalist who writes on security and intelligence issues, who raised the comparison with Rabin's assassination in a column for the Jerusalem Post. It was true, he noted, that Abu Khdair's murderers, like Amir, acted alone. But they didn't exist in a vacuum: they emerged from a society in which, as President Rivlin would soon argue, anti-Arab racism was widespread, and in which its ideologues were often coddled by the authorities.

> In recent years, the religious dimension has manifested itself in young right-wing terrorists and thugs from Jewish settlements in the West Bank, wrongly known as the Hillside Youth. They have burned and desecrated Arab mosques and cemeteries. Unfortunately the Shin Bet, police and other law enforcement agencies, including the courts, have responded by either turning a blind eye or not acting harshly enough. This is at least partially caused by the refusal of the government to